

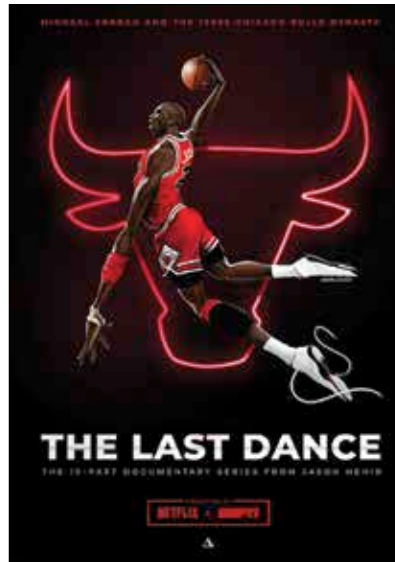
## DOCUMENTARY

## The Last Dance

★★★★★ | If you were a 90s kid (which most of you were probably not), and had even heard of the sport of basketball, you would know of Michael Jordan. The only MJ more famous than him was Michael Jackson, and there was no basketball star who shone brighter in the 90s.

Millions of kids across the world grew up playing basketball and making pathetic attempts at skills he would display on the court – some of us even sticking our tongues out to emulate him!

So great was his influence on basketball, and so dominant was the team he played for (at the time) – the Chicago bulls – that they won six titles in eight years! So great were



these heroes in our eyes, that fist fights would break out over anyone who dared insult them... and we weren't even from Chicago, or even American for that matter! Jordan was, and is, the Sachin of basketball.

Which brings us to this docu-series on Netflix that focuses on those

six titles in those eight magical years for every Chicago Bulls fan.

While most documentaries about the Bulls have focussed on their achievements on court, this documentary looks at the backroom, and wipes the sheen of stardom off so many of the players that we 90s kids grew up worshipping.

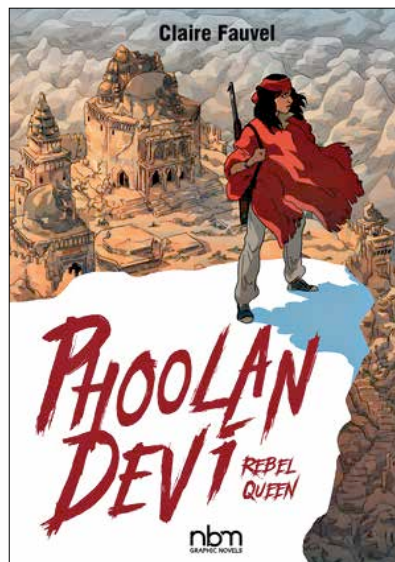
It also happens to be perfectly timed, because so many of us 90s kids are stuck at home because of the pandemic, all across the globe. We're older, and more prepared to see the reality that's revealed behind the scenes, which includes showing you just how boring people who strive for and achieve perfection can be, or how politics ruined a team that had never tasted this level of success before, and haven't since either.

You don't need to be a fan – of Jordan, the Bulls or even basketball – to enjoy this series, but if you are one, this will end up being a binge watch. Especially since it is one season with merely 10 episodes.

## GRAPHIC NOVEL

## Phoolan Devi: Rebel Queen

★★★★★ | The story begins in jail, just as Phoolan Devi is given a pardon, then goes into a flashback that tracks her journey right from childhood. While Claire Fauvel uses Phoolan Devi's own autobiography as the basis for the story, the amount of research done really comes across in the individual drawings and pages. The environment of a typical small town rural village in North India is captured perfectly, as are the minor details of buildings such as jails and police stations. The artwork is a treat even if you ignore the story, but it is something that simply cannot be ignored even if you try. The whole story is an emotional roller coaster, with tender moments between family and friends interspersed



with scenes of horrific and extreme violence. While the story is about grit and determination of Phoolan Devi, there is also a meta commentary on the caste system in India, the patriarchy, and the relentless lack of fairness in the machine. In a triumphant win, Phoolan Devi goes on to be and make

the change in the system, rebelling against injustice despite being a Bandit Queen. This is not a book for young kids, as there are some explicit but not gratuitous depictions of sexual violence, even against children.

This is a graphic novel that manages to be both harrowing and uplifting at the same time. The pacing is fast, and the storytelling is captivating. This is a page turner that you cannot put down. Through it all the focus is on exploring the journey of Phoolan Devi, from a poor girl in a low caste family, to a vigilante bandit who corrects the distribution of wealth in the system by robbing the rich and being charitable towards the poor, to finally a leader and social activist who goes on to become a successful politician. This is the showcase of a truly unique antihero turned hero who always lived life by her own terms no matter what obstacles came her way. In the middle of it all, there is also a poignant love story, where she ends up marrying a fellow bandit.